



has managed for most – if not the whole – of his existence. "The series was never about unmasking secret identities, which I think a lot of people who didn't read it thought it was. When I sat down and started writing, all the Marvel heroes had been unmasked over the previous ten years. Even Daredevil. I think Spider-Man was the only one who still had a secret ID."

There is one thing that Millar heralds above all else for the film adaptation: "For me the most important thing is Cap vs Iron Man. The two ideological conflicts are what's interesting about that story. I think there is something very emotive about seeing Captain America punching Iron Man in the face and vice versa."

Civil War isn't the first time that we have seen our favourite heroes go head-to-head ("In the 1960s you always have The Hulk vs The Thing and Captain America fighting, you know, another superhero. There is all the misunderstanding between two superheroes and they fought"). In the history of comics it is a common eventuality, but very few times has the outcome held such importance. *Civil War* had consequences. Events happened that the world couldn't come back from; Captain America ended up in jail, Tony Stark was the director of SHIELD and forming his own group of Avengers – later seen in *The Mighty Avengers* – and the Fifty State Initiative was launched. Somebody lost and somebody won.

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"You have to feel that pressure with every story or you're doing it wrong," said Millar of how he viewed the project in terms of scale. "Comics cost three or four dollars and it's hard-earned cash, so I try to put that pressure on myself whether it's a small story or a big, company event." As a result of that pressure, it became a stressful time in Millar's life. "It took me nine months to write that story and it was only a handful of issues. Ordinarily I'd have done something in half that time. But there was such a technical thing because I was tying in so many other people, which made it very difficult, but in the end I was very happy with it.

"It was one of those things where it was lovely to have it and put it on my shelf. It was a period of my life rather than an ongoing job because I think you would just go mad. And really, only a handful of people have done those big crossovers and I kind of get why. You kind of rarely get somebody doing it twice because it is such a lot of work."

Working on the comic too, Steve McNiven has collaborated on several of Millar's titles over the years. The writer speaks highly of his creative companion, "We just gel very well. *Nemesis* sold a huge number of books, *Old Man Logan* went down very well and *Civil War* was the bestselling series of that decade, so it was just one of those nice things where the chemistry was right and readers seemed to enjoy what we were doing." On working with McNiven for the first time he says: "You never know going in, but Steve is lovely and brilliant and it's not hard for him make a writer look good."

All of their hard work paid off, however, as the comic received



The Secret Service **looks a bit different to its film adaptation.**